

ABC of DEMENTIA

A progressive neural disorder that attacks brain cells and strips people of their memory, personality and a sense of the self

A

for everyday
ACTIVITIES that
get severely
affected

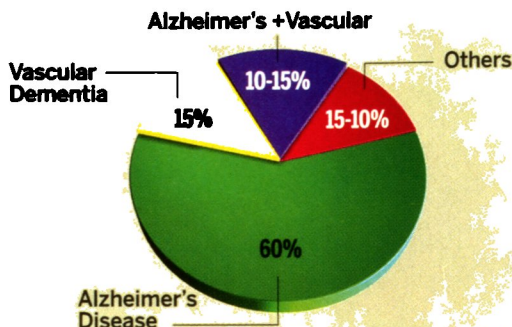
B

for BEHAVIOURAL
problems that
bring down the
quality of life

C

for ultimate
loss of COGNITIVE
FUNCTION and
memory

What causes DEMENTIA?



BAD NEWS

In India, **vascular dementia** is surging as lifestyle factors like obesity and diabetes push up stroke rates. It may overtake Alzheimer's Disease.

GOOD NEWS

Vascular diseases are partially preventable and treatable, so increasing awareness of this link may bring down the incidence of dementia.

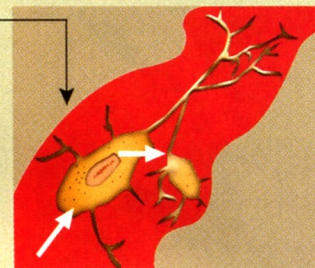
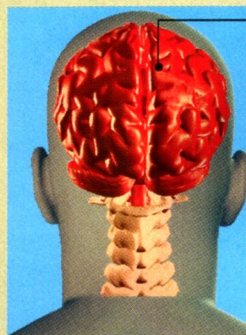
Death of a NEURON

1

Alzheimer's Disease is selective in the way it attacks the brain. It begins in the memory area, the hippocampus, and spreads slowly to other areas over a period of two to three years.

2

By the time one starts showing symptoms, 15% of brain matter is damaged beyond recovery.



Healthy Brain

Advanced Alzheimer's

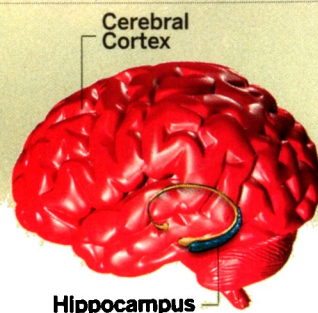


4

There is an overall shrinkage of brain tissue as more nerve cells die—very different from the normal ageing process. The furrows grow wider and folds in the brain's outer layer shrink rapidly.

3

As the disease spreads to the brain's outer layer (cerebral cortex) the sense of judgement declines and emotional outbursts become the order of the day.



people out of one lakh get a stroke each year, in India it's 300 out of one lakh.

Dementia is a slow burn that strips sufferers of memory, personality and eventually their humanity. "It refers to the whole class of conditions characterised by the deterioration of cognitive skills of a person, in two spheres—say, memory and calculation or memory and language—bringing one's quality of life down significantly," explains neurologist Dr Manjari Tripathi of the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), Delhi, who set

up the Cognitive Disorders Clinic 10 years back. "Dementia is the effect," clarifies Dr V.S. Natarajan, geriatrician who runs the Senior Citizens' Bureau in Chennai.

For over 60 per cent, the cause is Alzheimer's Disease. A further 20 per cent have vascular dementia, caused by mini-strokes which disrupt the blood supply to the brain—most common in people with heart disease and high blood pressure. The remaining 25 per cent have a range of causes, from hypothyroidism to vitamin B12 defi-

ciency, explains the man who authored *Goodbye To Dementia*. "Some are reversible, but the more deadly varieties—linked to Alzheimer's or Parkinson's—are incurable."

No one really knows why brain cells start dying. In Alzheimer's, the condition is thought to be caused by the build-up of protein deposits in the brain—plaques and tangles—whose first symptom may be a difficulty in finding words. "The only known risk factor is age," says Dr Mathew Verghese of the National Institute of

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